

Prologue

There is a small town in the countryside on a road travelers pass through. There are no other towns within three day's march.

The town is owned by the **Izas**, so they are its hosts. Tonight is the summer solstice, and the party are invited by **Nami** and **Nagi** to feast under their roof with the rest of the townsfolk. They are warmly welcomed with good food, and asked for stories. In turn, there is talk of a **great storm** coming tonight, which will wash away anyone without shelter.

Hiruko knocks at the door of the house, dressed in seal-skins. He is all canines, and looks very much like an ogre when he greets his mother and father. "Your eldest son has returned. I must be given a place to stay tonight."

The feast grows quiet.

Nami and **Nagi** look stricken.

"We have no room for you, Hiruko," **Nagi** says to his son, "for we have already given our spare room to travelers, and by the laws of hospitality, we cannot give them up."

Hiruko sneers in reply:

"Tonight, you cannot discard me like when I was a lame babe. Give me a room by midnight, or I will murder one of your townsfolk," and he gestures to those assembled.

"You were born without a heart,"

Nami says to her son, "would that you were never born," and she weeps.

Hearing this, the townsfolk leave the **Izas'** house, to go and board up their own.

Dramatis Personae

Nami and **Nagi** beseech the party, please stay—for if **Hiruko** is allowed to return, he will take his place as head of the house.

The orphan must have come, they reason, to claim their family's fortune, which they wish instead for their adopted son, **Susanoo**, to inherit. "The storm will surely wash the ogre away," they say, "so the townsfolk have nothing to worry about."

They think they could:

- Offer the party money for a project they desire, or property in town.
- Trap the party inside their guest-room, barring the door with a fireplace poker, during the storm.
- Bribe a covetous villager, **Jimmu**, to come over and occupy their guest-room.
- ... or anything else they can attempt with their small fortune, land-ownership, and the pistol they keep in their room. They are limited by their frailty and the law, which affords them all their power, and which they cannot imagine breaking in letter, if not spirit.

Nami. *As a lord.*

Nagi. *As a lord.*

Jimmu. *As a peasant.*

Pistol. Flintlock; single-shot.

Can't use wet powder.

Very damaging (2d6).

Amaterasu and **Tsukuyomi** are courageous sisters, and will not idle as their lives are gambled on, nor the rest of their town's lives.

They think they could:

- Find the party and offer them a place to stay for the night.
- Have **Tsukuyomi** sneak a cot into the **Izas'** living room, opening a window.
- Have **Amaterasu** find **Hiruko's** hiding spot, and expose it to someone.
- ... or anything else they can accomplish with their wits, their affections (both sisters wish to marry up in society), and their **lucky bracelets**. They are limited by the law and their poverty—anything rash they do tonight could get them jailed tomorrow.

Amaterasu. *As a peasant.*

Strong.

Tsukuyomi. *As a peasant.*

Dextrous.

Mino. Traditional rice-straw raincoat. Proper equipment to brave the storm.

Sun-bracelet. Amaterasu's.
Grants night-vision.

Moon-bracelet. Tsukuyomi's.
Grants obscurity in darkness.

Susanoo is a loud fifteen-year-old, but he has been very quiet tonight. He just learned of his older brother's existence, only to come to the conclusion that he must kill him to prevent a murder. He could not bear the thought of **Tsukuyomi**, whom he is sweet on, being threatened by **Hiruko**.

He thinks he could:

- Convince the party to bring **Tsukuyomi** to the house.
- Steal the **pistol** from his parent's bedroom, and sneak out to confront **Hiroku**.

- ... or anything else he can accomplish with his arrogance, parents' favor, and good intentions. He is limited only by what Tsukuyomi thinks of him and his tempestuous imagination.

Susanoo. *As a lord.*

Hiruko was abandoned by Nami and Nagi when he was born prematurely, but survived. He wants his revenge, especially to take their wealth from them, and to make them feel as powerless as he did as an orphan. Nonetheless, he wants to terrify rather than kill.

He thinks he could:

- Hide himself in the stable.
- Terrify a townspeople in their home, and let the whole village hear the screaming.
- Sneak into the **Izas'** house to take up an unoccupied room.
- ... or anything else he can accomplish with his cunning, strength, terrifying visage, sword, and thick sealskins.

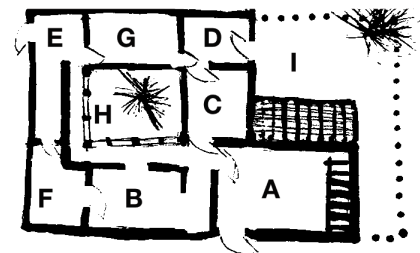
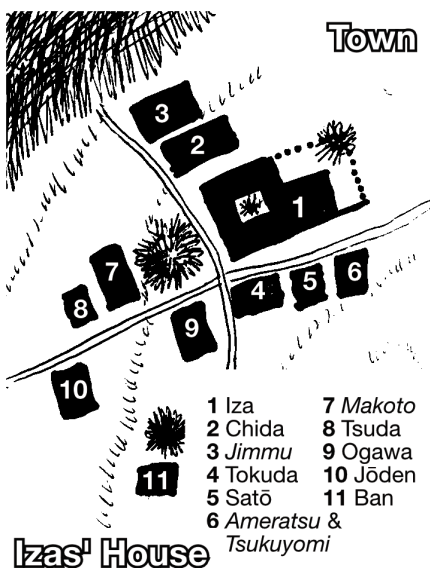
Hiroku. *As a soldier.*

Strong, dextrous, cunning.

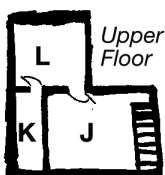
Seal-skins. The best rain gear available. Proper equipment to brave the storm.

Wakizashi. *As a shortsword.*

Model the rest of the **townsfolk** as peasants.



- A Dining
B Living
C Kitchen
D Entry
E Entry
F Guest-room
G Susanoo's room
H Garden
I Fenced yard
J Tea-room
K Closet
L Nami & Nagi's room



The Storm

At twilight, it begins to rain, and steadily grows in intensity. From true dusk until dawn, the storm is awesome. Any travel outside, however brief, soaks travelers to the bone. They must use their strength or become chilled, battered (1d6 damage), and lose an item they carry to the wind. Those with proper equipment to brave the storm have better odds.

Referee's Notes

The author recommends to play NPCs to the hilt, but clearly communicate their intentions where apparent, like describing a keyed location in a dungeon. Respond to the party's actions, and follow consequences to their logical conclusions. This story might be a tragedy, a thriller, or a picaresque.

Good luck, and have fun.